

■ SONIA GANDHI

Why did Italy-born Sonia Gandhi's foreign origin become an election issue in India? As far as the BJP is concerned, there were no personal considerations that guided our stand. I strongly disapproved of certain personalised comments on Sonia Gandhi during the campaign. Such personal criticism of a woman, and a widow at that, is clearly barred in India's cultural tradition, and nor can it have a place in democratic discourse. But, fundamentally, it was a matter of principle for us.

Sonia Gandhi, whose earlier name was Sonia Antonia Maino, came to India after her marriage to Rajiv Gandhi in 1968. But she did not apply for Indian citizenship even after she entered Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's household. Instead, she filed in application for permission to stay as a foreigner in India, which is granted for five years. After the expiry of the first five-year period, she re-applied twice, in 1973 and 1978, for permission to stay in India while keeping her status, as a foreigner. It was only on April 27, 1983, just three days before her third five-year permit expired, she renounced her Italian citizenship and opted to become an Indian citizen. The timing of her decision was revealing. It was influenced by the fact that her husband was then being groomed as the successor to Indira Gandhi. Therefore, the question that weighed on the minds of many Indians is: Why did Sonia Gandhi not take Indian citizenship for fifteen long years after coming to India, and even after giving birth to her two children here? Till date, she has not answered this question satisfactorily.

Question marks have been placed on some of Sonia Gandhi's actions during the period that she was not an Indian citizen. These have been well-documented. For instance, Sonia Gandhi had cast her vote in the 1980 parliamentary elections even though she was not a citizen of India then. How did she get her name in the voters' list?

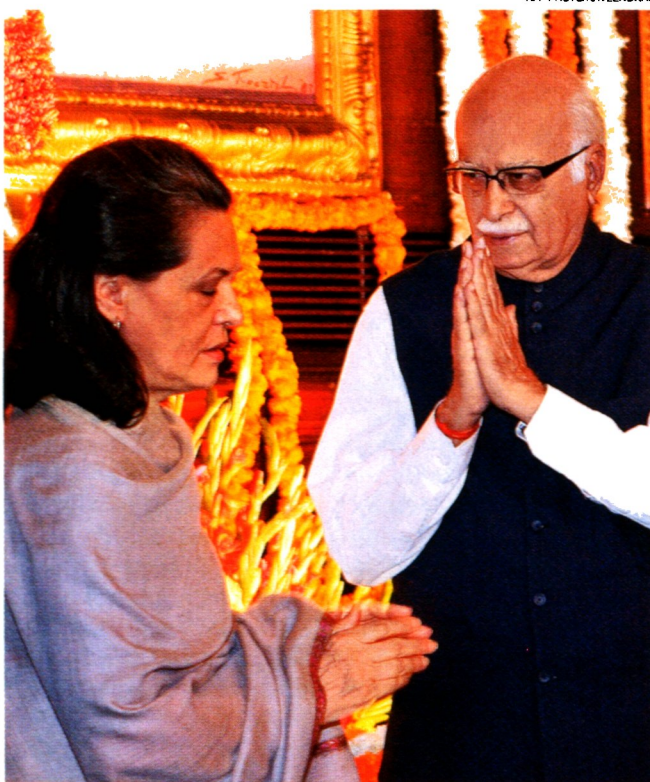
In many democratic countries, including the US and Italy, the law prohibits a person from holding the

highest public office unless he or she is native born. In India there is no such law, principally because the makers of our Constitution did not visualise a situation when the issue of foreign-origin of a political personality would dominate national debate in a manner that it did in the late 1990s. I would like to mention here that even Henry Kissinger, the legendary former secretary of state of the US, cannot run for presidential election in his country because he is foreign-born. Article II, Section 1 of the US Constitution allows only natural-born citizens to serve as president. The same limitation applies to Madeleine Albright, another former secretary of state, and Arnold Schwarzenegger, incumbent Governor of California.

Speaking for myself, what influenced my thinking on this issue was not so much the legal aspects of citizenship, important though they are in themselves. India is an open society and our culture is exceedingly accommodative and assimilative, especially when it comes to a person who enters one's family as a daughter-in-law. The mere fact of a person being foreign-born has never come in the way of Indians accepting such a person as their own. Two outstanding women from the pre-Independence era, who were foreigners but became an integral part of India's mind and soul, were Sister Nivedita and Annie Besant. Indian people recall their names with reverence even today.

Like every other Indian, I have my sympathies for Sonia

Gandhi for the tragedies that she has experienced in her life. I also admire the courage that she has displayed in overcoming them. Nevertheless, if there is one thing that has disappointed me the most, it is her active and irrefutable collusion in covering up the role of fellow Italian, Ottavio Quattrocchi, in the infamous Bofors scandal. It is devoid of any political morality and unbecoming of a person aspiring to hold the highest executive office in India. For achieving this cover-up, almost every institution of the Indian Republic—Prime Minister's Office, Law Ministry, Foreign Ministry, Defence Ministry, judiciary, CBI, Joint Parliamentary



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